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na game with a doosra: an Ahir leader as state chief, a Jat as CLP boss



DUOPOLY New Congress state chief Rao Narendra Singh with ex-CM Hooda

broader coalition spanning Jat, Ahir and Dalit votes, the fracturing of which had cost the party heavily in the 2024 assembly election. The BJP had swept southern Haryana: the Ahirwal belt, Rao's home turf. But a year on, the BJP exudes a sense of drift, sans a permanent state chief.

Rao's elevation ends months of speculation and factional lobbying. Opting to have a counterweight to Hooda is no small shift, for his sway over party and polity remain formidable. New Delhi's message seems nuanced: Hooda's era is far from over, but he must operate within a broader rubric that signals inclusivity on region and caste. Right after taking charge, Rao began engaging Hooda's rivals Birendra Singh, Randeep Singh Surjewala and Kumari Shelja, an early signal that he won't fight shy of rebalancing power equations.

Not that it will be easy. Among Ahirs, Rao is seen as a lightweight leader. His only poll victory came in 2009; he'd become the Narnaul MLA as a young rebel with ex-CM Bhajan Lal. Soon he was back in the Congress, and Hooda, then ruling the roost as CM, made him a minister. Since then, Rao has been humbled thrice from Narnaul by the BJP's Om Prakash Yadav.

The Ahirwal belt isn't easy terrain; its key nature is signified by six-time MP and Union minister Rao Inderjit Singh, whose shift to the BJP in 2014 has kept the balance tilted ever since. Rao Narendra will have to punch above his weight to fulfil a basic expectation from him: that of being able to woo some of his own community. He also has to manage factional pulls along all other axes, including any the power-sharing with Hooda may itself bring. Plus, Jat satraps like Birendra Singh and son Barjinder Singh are playing for more space, the father even launching a yatra in anticipation of any decline in Hooda's influence.

Too much friction there could fragment a core vote bank for the Congress, sabotaging the very idea of a caste coalition. So some of those ambitions will have to be subtly reined in. The idea is not to forfeit Hooda's mass appeal, but to extend the catchment area beyond his Jat base and to prevent any monopoly over the state unit. Rao's perch allows central oversight over the state's factionalised politics.

Takeaways

- **With Rao Narendra as state chief, Hooda's monopoly reign ends**
- **The idea is to widen party base to non-Jat castes: Ahirs, Dalits**
- **BJP, by contrast, is still unable to settle on a state party chief**

BJP'S LONG SEARCH

The BJP presents a stark contrast. That its search for a state president is ongoing even after months is revelatory. CM Nayab Singh Saini has to navigate competing pressures from loyalists of predecessor M.L. Khattar, the permanent malcontent Anil Vij, besides the BJP's own Jat and Ahir aspirants.

The lack of resolution has allowed Congress to seize the initiative and create a buzz at the grassroots in Ahirwal and Dalit-dominated constituencies. Social media chatter, local media headlines and community forums suggest Rao's appointment has catalysed conversations long dormant. But it will be up to Rao, up against titans on both sides, to translate symbolism into something material. ■